Although the UPWC was the officially designated institution for peace policy implementation, some members of the UPWC, including the chairman and most of its ethnic lawmaker members, were not actively involved in the overall peace process. Behind the scenes, there was a considerable amount of political maneuvering by key members of the MPC on peace negotiations between the Tatmadaw and the EAGs. Their crucial roles ranged from setting the strategic agenda of the state-initiated peace policy, implementing them, and reshaping directions of the policy process when needed, to supporting the day-to-day activities of the UPWC. Under the formal structure, the UPWC had the highest authority for policy implementation. However, it appears that the overall direction of the peace process was set through MPC policy devices: (i) membership; and (ii) shared goals and its coordination with key stakeholders.

Membership

One of the special characteristics of the MPC under the Thein Sein administration was its membership. The MPC mainly consisted of civilian exile-returned policy advocates headed by several powerful ministers. Aung Min himself was the chairman of the MPC, run by President Office Minister Soe Thein and Khin Yi, Minister for Population and Immigration. Its civilian technocrats included individual policy advocates from think tanks, such as Hla Maung Swe, Tin Maung Than, and returned exiled academics Dr Kyaw Yin Hlaing, Dr Min Zaw Oo, and Dr Salai Ngun Cung Lian. However, among all members, it appears that Aung Min held the highest mandate from the president for implementation of the government's overall peace plan from the beginning of the peace negotiation process.[5] Most of the other members have personal networks with some ethnic leaders and could provide technical assistance and detailed information on the peace project. Throughout the peace process, exchange of resources — executive power, personal networks with ethnic stakeholders, technical capacity, and information advantage — among members created privileged relationships. On the other hand, Team A, in which all individual members were soldiers-turned-lawmakers and executives, did not have such a distinctive membership apparatus with which to implement the peace policy. After Team A was dissolved in mid-2012, the peace process slowly turned into a non-bureaucratic affair driven by civilian technocrats (Transnational Institute 2015).